

Eames House

Location Los Angeles, California

Named for its designers and owners, Charles and Ray Eames, the Eames House was a product of the Case Study Houses program, the brainchild of John Entenza, the publisher of *Arts & Architecture* magazine. Its goal was to exploit the boom in the US house-building industry after World War II to champion Modernism. All the houses were to be economical and functional and to be made of mass-produced materials. Thirty-six designs were produced, and 26 were built. The Eames House, completed in 1949, sits on a wooded site of 54,000 square ft (5,000 square m). It consists of two simple rectangular buildings—the house and a studio—with their external walls divided into repeating colored rectangles. Internally, the most dramatic space is the double-height living room.

GM Technical Center

Location Michigan

The General Motors Technical Center, built between 1953 and 1955, is the first undisputed masterwork of the Finnish American architect Eero Saarinen. It is a corporate

► **THE WATER TOWER AT THE GM TECHNICAL CENTER**

campus arranged around two lakes on a landscaped site of 0.5 square miles (1.3 square km). The buildings are long, low, and flat-roofed, dominated by steel and glass. However, changes of scale aided by splashes of vivid color, often from glazed bricks, add an almost theatrical air to the monumentlike structures. The futuristic feel is epitomized by the sleek steel of the 180-ft- (55-m-) diameter Design Dome and the almost spaceshiplike 140-ft- (43-m-) tall water tower that rises from the larger of the lakes.

Crown Hall

Location Chicago, Illinois

The famous maxim of the German-born architect Ludwig Mies van der Rohe, “less is more,” is encapsulated by his Crown Hall at the Illinois Institute of Technology, built in 1956. It is a glass-and-steel rectangular box—220 ft (67 m) long, 120 ft (36 m) wide, and 18 ft (5.5 m) high—of absolute simplicity and minimal structure. The principal facade consists of six central glass bays created by vertical black steel supports. On either side, there are a

further eight bays. The flat roof is suspended from four large steel girders that span the building’s width. Everything else is glass—sandblasted for the lower 8 ft (2.5 m), but clear for the remaining 10 ft (3 m). The result is a brilliantly lit, entirely unobstructed interior.

Case Study House No. 21

Location Los Angeles, California

The most celebrated result of the Case Study Houses program (see also the Eames House, left) is the house known simply as No. 21, or the Bailey House, after its first owners, Walter and Mary Bailey. Designed by Pierre Koenig and completed in 1958, it is perhaps the purest statement of domestic Modernism ever built. It is not just functionally efficient; it is simple to the point of austerity. The floor plan is L-shaped. The walls are painted a uniform white. The south-facing front consists entirely of windows separated by steel supports. It is also water-cooled, with water pumped up to the roof being channeled to flow down the building. After a series of unsympathetic alterations, in 1997, Koenig restored the house to its original understated elegance.

